permitted in POTA) escaped much by way of scrutiny. The media nailed Geelani on the basis of this confession.

But the media did more. Newspapers detailed property Geelani is said to have amassed as rewards for his labours, as well as the minutiae of his contacts with a student of 'west Asian' origin who must have been an 'Arab terrorist'. But no newspaper or television channel ever mentioned that Afzal, identified as a former JKLF militant and fruit merchant, was in fact a 'surrendered militant' and that he had for seven years been harassed by, and on occasion worked for, the 'Special Task Force', a shadowy counter-terrorism outfit that operates with impunity in Kashmir. The fact remains that in his statement to the court Afzal said unequivocally that he met one Tariq, a trusted lieutenant of the arch-terrorist 'Ghazi Baba', who is said to have motivated him to return to the ways of the 'jihad for azaadi' in an STF training camp in Dral in south Kashmir, and his wife's statement that Afzal was instructed to bring two of the men, later identified as the 'slain terrorists' in the Parliament attack, to Delhi and provide them with shelter while they were in 'transit' by none other than his STF handlers, went unremarked, with one significant exception, to which we will refer later.

It is interesting to speculate as to how some stories made their way into the media, and how some stories remained virtually 'out of bounds' even if they made their appearance sometimes in court documents. It is also interesting to consider whether this pattern of omission and insertion or fabrication pointed to the collaborative authorship (between the police, the intelligence community, and the media professionals and channels/newspapers) of these media materials. It is still not clear as to where the origins of these stories lay, and why they appeared so frequently, and why they were given so much space. One thing is certain, the efficient public relations and media exercises carried out (whether through fear or favour, or simply, access) by the 'Special Cell' of the Delhi Police in order to make the journalist community simply reproduce what was fed to them in routine press briefings seems to have worked well. The operation worked particularly well with television, with several channels broadcasting 'exclusive' interviews with what seemed to be an affable and loquacious prime accused Mohammad Afzal on 20 December.

If media professionals highlighted elements from Afzal's first 'confessions' in custody to substantiate their allegations against Geelani, they also obscured the fact that later, during the filming of the 'broadcast confession' of 18 December, Afzal explicitly denied the fact that Geelani had anything to do